schemes, termed Navaratnalu (Nine Gems) by Jagan.

On May 2, the CM unleashed the 'Jagan Kosam Siddham' (We are ready for Jagan) campaign in which over 250,000 party cadres spread out across 47,000 polling booths and visited most of the 16.7 million households to brief everyone about Jagan's promises under the 2024 poll manifesto—Navaratnalu Plus. The manifesto, unveiled on April 27, eschewed grand new schemes and promised to implement continuing ones with increased allocation for some and a raise in welfare pension. YSRCP workers also reminded people that Jagan was the only chief minister who fulfilled all his 2019 manifesto promises and transformed the lives of beneficiaries. This saturation bombing, as it were, of the grassroots sprang from the confidence that welfare measures had touched almost all families at the bottom half of the pyramid.

The YSRCP has also taken care to carry all caste groups along in its welfare drive. "Through deft social engineering since 2019, the reworked social base for the YSRCP, beginning with a Jagan cabinet having ministers from key castes and cohorts, has meant that the clout of many individual strongmen of various castes is diminished," says Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at the NALSAR University, Hyderabad.

Caste Matters

Political parties can ill afford to ignore the caste balance. Indeed, under Jagan, Andhra was the second state in the country to carry out a caste census early this year. When accused of doing it to extract electoral advantage, Jagan countered that it would promote data-driven governance. The findings have not been put in the public domain. According to previously available information, the Backward Classes (BC), which include 143 different caste groups, comprise about 37 per cent of the state's population of 49.8 million. The forward Kapu castes and various related groups are numerically significant too, constituting about 16 per cent. The influential Reddys (Jagan's caste) account for about eight per cent, and the mercantile Kamma caste, from which Naidu hails, comprise six per cent of the population respectively.

Just as Jagan is balancing Reddys with other castes, Naidu and the NDA are relying on Kamma domination. Predictably, for the 175 assembly seats, the YSRCP is fielding as many as 49 Reddys, while 29 find their way in the three-party alliance. Again, the NDA has 35 Kammas in the race, as opposed to nine in the YSRCP list. There are 22 Kapus, too, on that list, more than the 18 in the NDA. In fact, the YSRCP has fielded more candidates from among the BCs and Muslims too—41 and 7—compared to the 39 and 3 in the NDA roster.

For the Lok Sabha polls, the YSRCP has fielded 11 BC contestants, and the NDA six. Among Other Castes (OCs) or general category, both have fielded five each from the forward Reddy community. The YSRCP has one Kamma and three Kapu candidates, while the alliance has fielded five Kammas and two Kapus.

Naidu's 'Assurances'

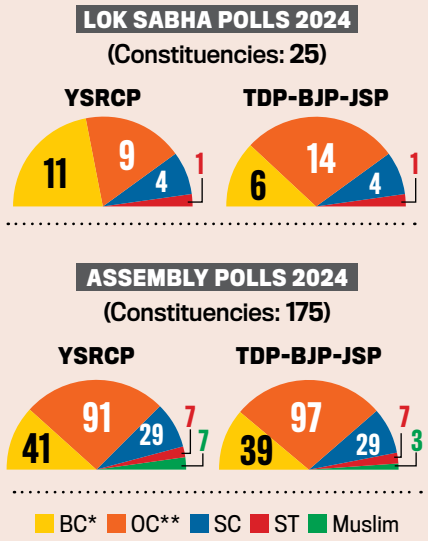
Chandrababu Naidu's campaign also includes a barrage of yatras and programmes. It began last year, with the TDP first family covering constituencies according to a plan. First, Naidu dispatched son Nara Lokesh, a Stanford graduate and the TDP national general secretary, on the 'Yuva Galam Padayatra' (Voice of Youth March) from January 27, 2023, starting from his own Kuppam assembly constituency. The intent, as Lokesh put it, was to reassure the 50 million people of Andhra "who have become victims of Jagan Mohan Reddy's corruption and anarchy". The padayatra was immensely popular, despite challenges forcing Lokesh to pause, such as after Naidu's arrest in September 2023 in the alleged AP State Skill Development Corporation scandal. In all, Lokesh trekked 3,132 km across 97 assembly segments to make the most of any anti-incumbency sentiment, before concluding the padayatra on December 20. Though he had narrowly lost the 2019 assembly polls from Mangalagiri (by 5,337 votes), Lokesh is confident of avenging that loss in 2024.

Even before Lokesh's padayatra had ended, Naidu's wife Nara Bhu-

CASTE CALCULUS

All caste categories are represented in the YSRCP and NDA lists. Muslims are fielded only for assembly polls

CASTEWISE BREAK-UP OF CANDIDATES



*Backward Classes, **Other Category